PUNJABI COLLECTION

NO. 10



NORTH INDIA ORIGIN

Matar Paneer

Paneer & Green Pea Curry

The Everyday Paneer Dish Every Household Knows

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Matar Paneer

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Contact: support@dhaniodigital.com

ABOUT THIS BOOK

Matar Paneer

AUTHOR

Sweta Verma

PUBLISHER

DhanioDigital

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DISCLAIMER

Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Everyday Curry Behind the Restaurant Favorites

Before butter paneer and shahi paneer became restaurant menu stars, matar paneer was already a fixture of North Indian home kitchens — a simpler, lighter, everyday curry that doesn't rely on cream or cashews, just a straightforward tomato-onion gravy studded with peas and cubes of fresh paneer. It's the paneer dish most North Indians actually grew up eating on a regular Tuesday, not just at celebrations.

Green peas have a long history in North Indian winter cooking, when fresh peas are at their sweetest and most abundant, and their pairing with paneer likely developed simply from what was seasonally available in home kitchens — a practical, unpretentious combination rather than a dish invented at any particular restaurant or by any particular chef.

Its very ordinariness is part of its appeal. Matar paneer represents the vast, less-photographed majority of Indian home cooking — dishes made for a Tuesday dinner rather than a wedding banquet, relying on good technique and fresh ingredients rather than lavish amounts of cream and butter to taste genuinely good.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Everyday Curry Behind the Restaurant Favorites, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

A staple of everyday North Indian home cooking, less associated with restaurants and celebrations than butter paneer or shahi paneer. Traditionally made with fresh winter peas, when they're at their sweetest, though frozen peas are now used year-round. Represents the practical, everyday cooking that makes up the majority of North Indian home kitchens, as opposed to richer special-occasion dishes. A dish most North Indians associate specifically with home-cooked family meals rather than dining out.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

10m	25m	4	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Kadai or wide pan
- Wooden spoon or spatula

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Matar paneer keeps refrigerated for up to 3 days and reheats well. It freezes reasonably well for up to a month, though the peas and paneer texture soften somewhat — for the best texture, some cooks prefer to freeze just the gravy and add fresh peas and paneer when reheating.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the curry

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Oil or ghee	2 tbsp	30 ml	2 chammach
Cumin seeds	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Onion, finely chopped	1 medium	100 g	1 medium
Ginger-garlic paste	1 tbsp	15 g	1 chammach
Tomatoes, pureed	2 medium	200 g	2 medium
Turmeric powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Coriander powder	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Red chili powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Garam masala	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Water	1 cup	240 ml	1 katori
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste

To finish

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Green peas, fresh or frozen	1 cup	150 g	1 katori
Paneer, cubed	250 g	250 g	250 g
Fresh coriander, chopped, for garnish	2 tbsp	8 g	2 tbsp

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Frozen peas work just as well as fresh in this dish and are what most home cooks reach for year-round — no need to thaw before adding, as they'll cook through quickly in the simmering gravy. This is one of the simplest and most globally accessible recipes in the collection, using only pantry staples and produce found in virtually any grocery store, making it an easy entry point for cooks new to Indian cuisine.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Building the Gravy

01 BLOOM THE CUMIN

Heat oil or ghee in a kadai and add the cumin seeds, letting them sizzle for a few seconds until fragrant.

02 SAUTÉ THE ONIONS

Add the chopped onion and sauté until golden, about 6–7 minutes. Stir in the ginger-garlic paste and cook until fragrant, about 1 minute.

03 ADD TOMATO AND SPICES

Pour in the tomato puree along with the turmeric, coriander powder, chili powder, and garam masala. Simmer for 8–10 minutes, until the mixture thickens and the oil separates slightly at the edges.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Building the Gravy, continued



Chef tip. this gravy is meant to stay lighter and thinner than butter paneer's — resist the urge to add cream, which would change the dish's whole character.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The gravy base is ready when it's noticeably thickened and the raw tomato smell has cooked off, replaced by a rounder, more savory aroma.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Finishing the Curry

04 ADD WATER AND PEAS

Pour in the water and add the green peas. Bring to a simmer and cook for 8–10 minutes, until the peas are tender — a shorter time if using frozen peas, since they cook quickly.



05 ADD THE PANEER

Gently fold in the paneer cubes and simmer for 3–4 minutes, just until warmed through — avoid overcooking, as paneer can turn firm with extended cooking.

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Finishing the Curry, continued

Texture indicator. matar paneer should have a thinner, lighter gravy than richer paneer curries, coating rather than clinging heavily to the paneer and peas.

06 GARNISH AND SERVE

Finish with a scatter of fresh coriander just before serving.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Overcooking the paneer once it's added is the most common mistake with this quick-cooking dish — add it toward the end and simmer only briefly to keep it soft and tender.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served hot with simple phulka or roti, exactly as it's eaten in North Indian homes on any given weeknight.
- A common lunchbox and everyday family meal, valued for being quick, light, and satisfying.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a bowl garnished with fresh coriander, often alongside a more elaborate menu of richer curries.

Family Style

- A quick, dependable weeknight dinner alongside rice or roti and a simple side salad.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Balance Right

- This dish shouldn't taste like a diluted butter paneer — its lighter gravy is intentional, letting the peas' natural sweetness come through.
- Fresh, sweet peas in season make a genuinely noticeable difference if you can find them, though frozen peas are a completely valid everyday choice.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- The gravy base can be made ahead and refrigerated for a few days, with peas and paneer added fresh when reheating for the best texture.
- This is one of the quickest curries in the collection, making it a practical everyday option even without much advance preparation.

RESTAURANT TRICK

A small pat of butter stirred in at the very end, off the heat, gives this simple everyday dish a touch of extra richness without turning it into a heavier restaurant-style curry.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

260 kcal	12 g	14 g	17 g	4 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with cream, butter, and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Restaurant-Style Matar Paneer	enriched with a touch of cream for a slightly richer version.
Dry Matar Paneer	a version with little to no gravy, the peas and paneer coated in a thick, dry spice mixture.
Aloo Matar Paneer	a heartier variation with diced potatoes added alongside the peas and paneer.

Can I use frozen peas?

Yes, frozen peas work very well and are what most home cooks use — no need to thaw them first, just add straight to the simmering gravy.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Why is my gravy too thin or too thick?

Adjust the water quantity — this dish is meant to have a lighter, thinner consistency than richer paneer curries, so don't over-reduce it.

Is this dish very spicy?

No — it's one of the mildest curries in this collection, making it a good introduction for those new to Indian food or cooking for children.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Matar	Hindi for green peas, the defining addition alongside paneer in this dish.
Paneer	fresh, non-melting Indian cheese made from curdled milk.
Phulka	a simple, soft stovetop roti, the everyday pairing for this dish.
Handi	a traditional narrow-necked pot sometimes used for serving curries.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Matar Paneer

10m	25m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
4	Easy
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

CURRY

Oil or ghee	30 ml
Cumin seeds	4 g
Onion	100 g
Ginger-garlic paste	15 g
Tomatoes	200 g
Turmeric powder	1.5 g
Coriander powder	3 g
Red chili powder	1.5 g
Garam masala	1.5 g
Water	240 ml
Salt	6 g

TO FINISH

Green peas	150 g
Paneer	250 g
Fresh coriander	8 g

METHOD

01 **Bloom the cumin.** Heat oil or ghee in a kadai and add the cumin seeds, letting them sizzle for a few seconds until fragrant.

02 **Sauté the onions.** Add the chopped onion and sauté until golden, about 6–7 minutes.

03 **Add tomato and spices.** Pour in the tomato puree along with the turmeric, coriander powder, chili powder, and garam masala.

04 **Add water and peas.** Pour in the water and add the green peas.

05 **Add the paneer.** Gently fold in the paneer cubes and simmer for 3–4 minutes, just until warmed through — avoid overcooking, as paneer can turn firm with extended cooking.

06 **Garnish and serve.** Finish with a scatter of fresh coriander just before serving.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Oil or ghee	30 ml	☐ Cumin seeds	4 g
☐ Onion	100 g	☐ Ginger-garlic paste	15 g
☐ Tomatoes	200 g	☐ Turmeric powder	1.5 g
☐ Coriander powder	3 g	☐ Red chili powder	1.5 g
☐ Garam masala	1.5 g	☐ Salt	6 g
☐ Green peas	150 g	☐ Paneer	250 g
☐ Fresh coriander	8 g		

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